



LOCALISATION

THE STATUS OF INDIC LOCALISATION

Having understood the history and growing importance of localisation in India, as well as the key local initiatives being taken in the previous article of this series, let us now look at the status of localisation in Indian languages, and the potential for growth.

Part—2

Let's first take a look at the status of localisation in India from the localiser's perspective. In order to quantify the status of localisation, we need to make a few choices about the software components. A computer user experiences several software, right from the moment the computer is switched on till it is switched off. These include boot and installation programs, the Graphical User Interface (GUI), a browser and several application software.

In the past, installation programs supported only English. After the introduction of GUIs and the progress in localisation, installation software (except for the initial boot screen) started supporting non-English languages. For the purposes of assessment, I've picked the Debian installer, as Debian and its derivatives have the maximum usage.

Many different GUIs are available in the free software world; GNOME and KDE are the most common, and GNOME is the most popular, which is why I've chosen to

analyse the extent of its localisation. Of the many different browsers that are available, Firefox is the most popular, hence fits the bill for our analysis.

Software applications are specific to a task—whether preparing documents, analysing data, preparing presentations, working with pictures, playing music or video, etc. An office package that comes with a word processor, spreadsheet and presentation software has become perhaps the most common application. LibreOffice (a fork of OpenOffice) is the most common office software for free software users; hence, it has been selected as the fourth component for analysis.

For the 22 official Indian languages, the status of support for each of the selected software components, in their latest versions (in terms of release, beta, or non-availability (NA)) is given in Table 1.

When you carefully analyse the data, you will find that:

- Urdu has zero localisation.